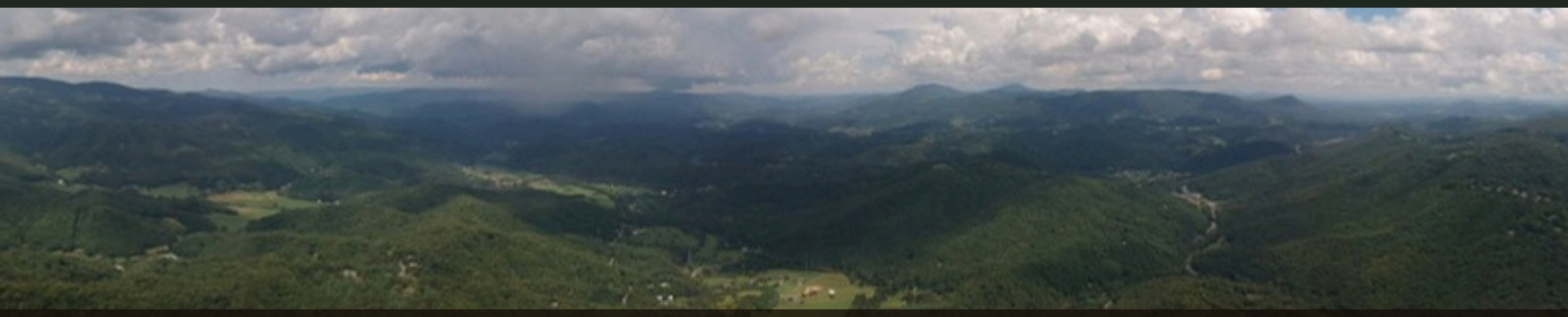
WATAUGA · AVERY · ASHE · WILKES COUNTIES

Buying Land in the High Country

It's not as simple as finding a pretty view and putting a camper on it. This guide covers everything you actually need to know before you buy mountain land in the High Country.

Andrew Plyler, REALTOR®/Broker
Blue Ridge Realty & Investments · Boone, NC 28607
770.639.1233 · aplyler@brri.net · https://plyler.realtor



© Andrew Plyler — Aerial view of the NC High Country, Watauga County. Every parcel in this terrain requires serious due diligence.

⚠ READ THIS FIRST — MOUNTAIN LAND IS DIFFERENT

Buying mountain land is not like buying a suburbanlot. Thereis no city water. There may be no road. There may be no power. The view you fell in love with may sit on a 45-degree slope that can't be built on. A beautiful 10-acre parcel without a passing perc test, legal road access, or buildable land is a very expensive problem. I've watched buyers make every one of these mistakes. This guide exists so you don't.

3,000–5,500 ft	30%+	5 Counties	8+
HIGH COUNTRY ELEVATION RANGE	SLOPES THAT LIMIT BUILDING	ASHE | AVERY | WATAUGA WILKES | CALDWELL	DUE DILIGENCEITEMSREQUIRED

CHAPTER 1 Zoning & Land Use — What Can You Actually Do With It?

Zoning determines what you can build, how many structures are permitted, minimum lot sizes, setbacks, and whether rentals are allowed. In the High Country, zoning varies dramatically between municipal and unincorporated county land — and the difference matters enormously.

MUNICIPAL VS. COUNTY ZONING

- **Townof Boone:** 21 zoningdistrict classifications, strictly enforced. Check townofboone.net/planning
- **Watauga County:** More permissive outside municipalities. See wataugacounty.org/planning
- **Avery & Ashe Counties:** Generally more rural — but always verify before buying. Don't assume.
- **ETJ:** Towns can extend zoning beyond their limits. Know if your parcel is in an Extra-Territorial Jurisdiction before you close.

WHAT TO VERIFY BEFORE CLOSING

- Permitted uses for the specific zoningdistrict
- Minimum lot size and setback requirements
- Whether STRs, campgrounds, or accessory structures are allowed
- Flood zone designation — check FEMA FIRM maps for the parcel
- Any pending rezoning or overlay districts affecting the land
- Whether the parcel is inside city limits, ETJ, or unincorporated county
- Agricultural exemptions if applicable — affects taxation significantly

CHAPTER 2 Perc Tests & Septic — The #1 Deal-Killer in Mountain Land

If a property is not on public sewer — and most High Country land is not — you will need a conventional or alternative septic system. Before that system can be permitted, the soil must pass a percolation test.

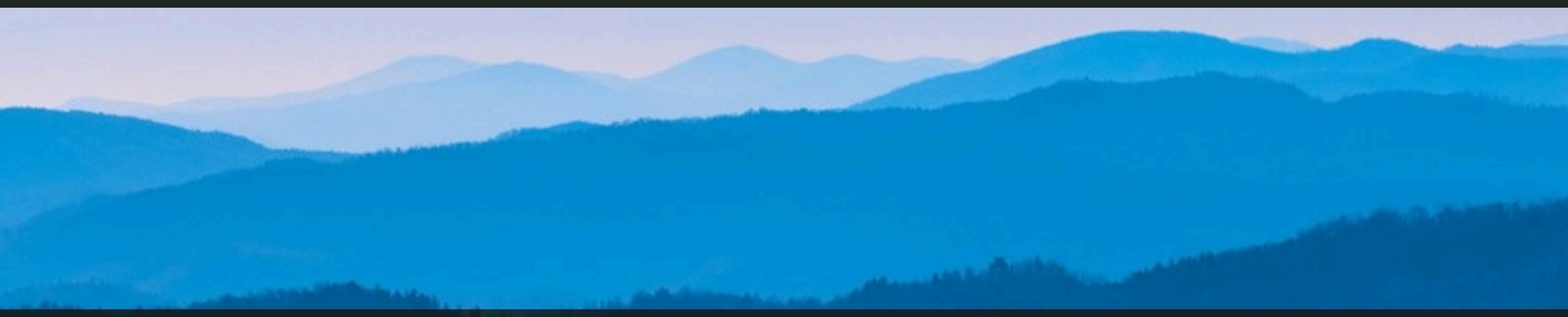
WHAT IS A PERC TEST?

- A soil evaluation testing how well the ground absorbs water
- Required before a septic permit can be issued in NC
- Administered by a licensed soil scientist or county health dept.
- Results determine system type, size, and placement on the lot
- Rocky, steep, or wet soils fail frequently — especially at elevation
- Perc tests typically cost $500–$1,500 — money very well spent

IF THE PERC TEST FAILS

- Noconventionalseptic=no building permit for a permanent structure
- Alternative systems (mound, drip irrigation): $15,000–$40,000+
- Some parcels have no viable septic solution at any cost
- **Always include a perc testing in your due diligence**
- Never waive this contingency regardless of seller pressure
- A failed perc is a legitimate reason to walk away — use it

> *I've watched buyers skip the perc test to speed things up and end up owning an unbuildable lot. This is the single most important contingency in any NC mountain land contract. Do not waive it.*



© Andrew Plyler — Layered Blue Ridge ridgelines at dusk. The beauty is real — so is the complexity of owning land here.

CHAPTER 3 Wells & Water — When There's No Public Water

PRIVATE WELL BASICS

- Most rural High Country parcels rely entirely on private wells
- Well depth: 100 to 600+ feet in mountain terrain — no way to know without drilling
- Drilling costs: $15–$30+ per foot — a 400-ft well runs $8,000–$12,000+
- Ask neighbors about their well depth as a baseline estimate
- Rock fractures determine water yield — no guarantees until drilled
- A hydrogeology assessment can reduce risk on expensive parcels
- NC well permitting required — get familiar with Watauga County EHS

WATER SOURCE ALTERNATIVES

- **Communitywater systems:**Some rural subdivisions have shared systems — verify capacity, maintenance status, and monthly cost
- **Springs:** Test flow rate and purity; spring rights must be explicitly established in the deed
- **Cisterns:** Non-potable use only in most jurisdictions
- **Public water extension:** Get cost estimate — can run $10,000–$50,000+ depending on distance and terrain
- **No water source at all:** Some remote parcels have no viable option — know this before you close

CHAPTER 4 Running Power to the Property

Many rural mountain parcels have no power at the property line. Extending electrical service up a steep road or through dense forest is one of the most underestimated costs in mountain land — budget for it before you fall in love with the view.

POWER EXTENSION COSTS

- Duke Energyand BlueRidge Energy serve most of the High Country
- Cost to extend: **$10–$30 per linear foot**
- 1,000-ft extension to a remote lot = $10,000–$30,000+
- Underground vs. overhead lines have different costs and permit requirements
- Get a written cost estimate from the utility provider before closing — not after
- Transformer placement adds cost on longer runs

OFF-GRID CONSIDERATIONS

- Solar + batterysystems are viable for remote parcels in the right exposure
- Quality solar system with battery backup: $25,000–$60,000+
- Starlink satellite internet now viable at most elevations
- Propane typically used for heat and cooking off-grid
- Generator is a bridge, not a permanent solution
- Building permits are still required regardless of power source

CHAPTER 5 Private Roads & Road Maintenance Agreements

WHAT TO INVESTIGATE

- Isaccess via a **public road, deeded easement, or private road?**
- Who owns the road — one party or multiple landowners?
- Is there a written, recorded **Road Maintenance Agreement (RMA)?**
- Road surface — gravel, dirt, or asphalt? What condition?
- Year-round passability — including winter snow and spring mud
- Grade and width — can emergency vehicles access the property?

WHY ROAD ACCESS IS CRITICAL

- Without a recordedeasement, you may have no legal right of access
- No RMA = no agreement on who pays for grading or repairs
- Shared road + uncooperative co-owners = expensive legal dispute
- Lenders often require legal road access before financing
- Road maintenance costs: $2,000–$10,000/yr for longer private roads
- Snow removal on private mountain roads falls entirely on the owner

CHAPTER 6 Grading, Driveways & Site Preparation

Getting a mountain site ready to build requires significant grading, retaining walls, driveway construction, and erosion control — all before a foundation is poured. These costs catch buyers off guard regularly.

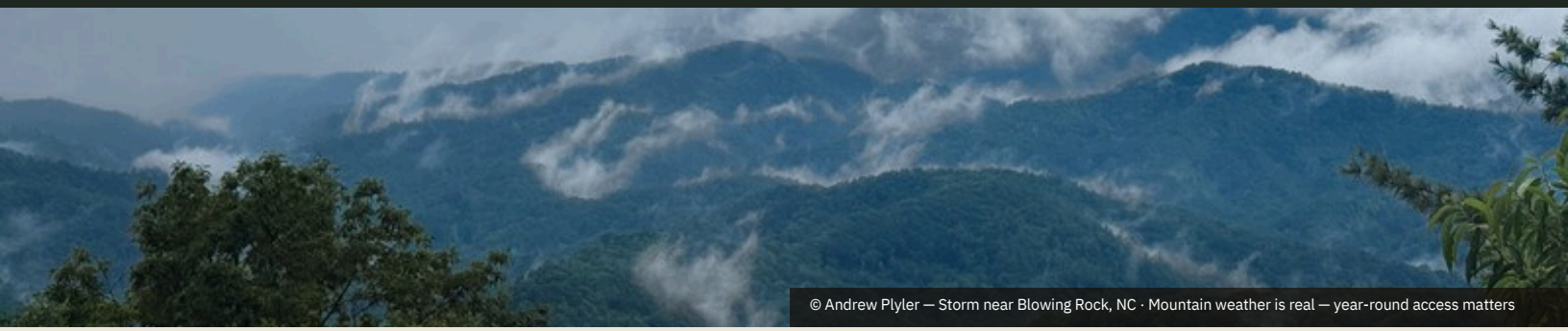
SITE PREP COST RANGES

Basic driveway (gentle slope)	**$8,000–$20,000**
Driveway (steep mountain lot)	**$20,000–$80,000+**
Engineered retaining walls	**$15,000–$60,000+**
Site clearing and grading	**$5,000–$25,000**
Blasting for rock outcroppings	**$5,000–$30,000+**
Erosion control and seeding	**$2,000–$10,000**

WHAT TO CHECK BEFORE CLOSING

- Slopesover30% require engineeredretaining walls — get a structural engineer involved early
- A flat buildable envelope must actually exist somewhere on the lot
- Grading permits required — Watauga County enforces erosion control rules strictly
- Get a civil engineer site assessment on any steep lot before closing
- Blasting may be required for rock outcroppings — permitted process, adds weeks and cost
- Confirm the building site doesn't sit in a flood zone or wetland setback

> *Before closing on any lot with slope, always hire a civil engineer to walk the site and identify the buildable envelope, driveway path, and estimated site prep costs. $500–$1,500 spent on this assessment can save you from a $50,000 surprise.*



© Andrew Plyler — Storm near Blowing Rock, NC · Mountain weather is real — year-round access matters

Easements & Rights-of-Way

Easements grant others the right to use a portion of your land. They restrict where you can build and may significantly impact usability.

- Review the title commitmentfor all recorded easements
- Utility easements restrict building in affected corridors — get their locations on a survey
- Prescriptive easements (long-term neighbor use) may not appear in title but are legally enforceable
- Neighbor access easements can impact how you use the land
- Pipeline and transmission line easements can cross large portions of a lot
- Get a survey showing all easement locations before closing

Cemeteries on the Property

Historic family cemeteries are remarkably common on mountain land in western NC — and NC law gives them powerful, permanent protections.

- **Walk the property before closing** — look for grave markers, fencing,or depressions
- A cemetery cannot be relocated or built over without a court order
- Family members retain the right of access by NC statute — in perpetuity — regardless of who owns the land
- Have your attorney review any cemetery-related language in the deed
- More common than most buyers expect in rural Watauga, Ashe, and Avery counties

POA & Deed Restrictions

POA rules and deed restrictions run with the property — they bind every future owner and cannot be easily removed.

- Read allCC&Rs (covenants, conditions & restrictions)in fullbefore closing
- POA fees: $200–$3,000+/yr — verify the POA's financial health and reserve fund
- Restrictions may limit: structure size, materials, rental use, animals, vehicle storage, build timelines
- Some POAs have architectural review committees with real veto authority
- Underfunded POAs are a significant long-term financial red flag
- Verify whether roads inside the development are POA-maintained or public

Timber, Mineral & Other Severed Rights

In mountain land, what you see on the surface is not always what you own. Severed rights are a critical title review item.

- **Timber rights:** Some deeds conveysurface only— a prior owner may retain the right to harvest timber
- **Mineral rights:** Oil, gas, coal, and mineral extraction rights can be severed and held separately
- **Water rights:** Spring and creek rights must be explicitly included in the deed
- Review the full chain of title for any severance language
- Ask your attorney to confirm exactly what rights transfer with the deed

DUE DILIGENCE Land Buyer's Checklist — Before You Remove Contingencies

- ☐ Perc test completed and passed — never waive this
- ☐ Well feasibility assessed (neighbor depth data or hydrogeology study)
- ☐ Legal road access confirmed and recorded in deed or easement
- ☐ Road Maintenance Agreement reviewed and understood
- ☐ Power availability and extension cost confirmed with utility in writing
- ☐ Zoning and permitted uses verified directly with county or town planning
- ☐ Flood zone check completed (FEMA FIRM maps)
- ☐ Slope analysis done — buildable envelope confirmed by civil engineer
- ☐ Survey ordered — all easements, boundaries, and encroachments shown
- ☐ Title commitment reviewed — all encumbrances identified
- ☐ Property physically walked — cemetery or grave markers checked
- ☐ POA documents and CC&Rs reviewed in full
- ☐ Deed restrictions reviewed and understood
- ☐ Timber and mineral rights confirmed in deed chain
- ☐ Internet and cell coverage tested on-site during the due diligence period
- ☐ Licensed NC real estate attorney engaged for closing

A note from Andrew: I've walked hundreds of mountain parcels over 40+ years in the High Country. The buyers who have the best experiences are the ones who slow down during due diligence and ask every question — even the uncomfortable ones. The ones who rush, skip the perc test, or assume access is legal are the ones who call me a year later with a problem. Take your time. Do it right. The right parcel is worth waiting for.

Andrew Plyler, REALTOR®/Broker

Blue Ridge Realty & Investments · Boone, NC28607

Deep High Country roots · 40+ years local experience · App State alumnus

I've walked hundreds of mountain parcels. I know what to look for — and what to walk away from.

770.639.1233 · aplyler@brri.net · plyler.realtor